



THE WEEK

Junior

Making sense of the world

THE BEST MAGAZINE FOR CURIOUS KIDS

TOP DOGS

The 150th Westminster Dog Show crowns its furry finalists and Best in Show winner p3



JJ
Non-Sporting Group



Penny
Best in Show



Zaida
Hound Group



Cookie
Toy Group



Graham
Herding Group



Wager
Terrier Group



Cota
Sporting Group



This week's big news



DID YOU KNOW?
Since 1981, there have been five shutdowns of the US government lasting between five and 43 days.

The US Capitol building, where Congress meets

Protests continue



On January 30, people across the US staged a boycott against ICE by staying home from work and school and avoiding shopping. Students who did go to school walked out of class in Georgia, California, and many other states. The next day, thousands of people joined "ICE Out of Everywhere" protests around the country.

Congress reaches agreement on budget

On February 3, after weeks of uncertainty and negotiations, members of the US Congress (branch of government that makes laws) reached an agreement on the annual budget that funds the government.

What happened before February 3?

Each year, both halves of Congress—the House of Representatives and the Senate—must approve the US government's budget with a majority vote. In October 2025, when Republicans and Democrats could not agree on a budget, the government went into a shutdown. It lasted 43 days, which was the longest shutdown in US history. In November, the parties reached an agreement that reopened the government. According to the agreement, some parts of the federal government were funded through September 2026. But much of the funding expired on January 30. Members of Congress could not reach a compromise by that time, so the government went into a partial shutdown the next day. Essential workers, such as air traffic controllers and members of the military, were required to keep performing their jobs without pay. When that happens, workers receive their pay later.

What is the disagreement about?

Democrats would not approve the budget because it included \$64 billion for the Department of Homeland Security (DHS). DHS implements the nation's immigration policies, including deporting (removing from the country) people from other nations who are in the US without legal permission. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agency is overseen by DHS. Most Democrats said they would not approve the budget bill until DHS procedures are reformed.

How was the disagreement resolved?

Republicans and Democrats negotiated until February 3, when they reached a deal to fund every part of the budget through September except DHS, which was funded only until February 13. That gave leaders 10 days to negotiate reforms to the agency. The Senate approved the bill in a 71–29 vote, and the House passed it by a narrow margin of 217–214. President Donald Trump signed the bill the same day, and the government reopened.

What do Democrats want?

After several weeks of widespread anger and nationwide protests over the actions of agents

employed by DHS and ICE, Democrats demanded several changes. They want to prohibit ICE and other federal agents from wearing masks and require them to wear body cameras and carry visible identification. They also want ICE to stop conducting random immigration sweeps and for the agency to be required to obtain warrants (legal permission issued by a judge) before stopping people on the street and searching them. Finally, Democrats want ICE officers to be held to the same standards as community law enforcement when using force. That means using the minimum force necessary to make arrests, avoiding force when possible, and using deadly force only as a last resort.

What will happen next?

Democrats and Republicans will negotiate reforms to DHS policy. Republicans said they are willing to work with Democrats and that all DHS agents will be issued body cameras immediately. But they also indicated that they will not compromise on certain aspects of immigration enforcement, including agents wearing face masks or not having to display identification. If the two parties fail to reach a deal by February 13, DHS will shut down until a budget is approved. ICE, however, would most likely continue to operate because it was given a budget of \$170 billion in 2025.



Funding for DHS will be discussed.



Border crossing to Gaza reopens

The Rafah crossing, a route connecting the Palestinian territory of Gaza with Egypt, reopened on February 2. It has been restricted since a war between Israel and Hamas (a terrorist group based in Gaza) began in 2023 and almost entirely closed since May 2024, when Israel took control of it. It is the only route out of Gaza that doesn't lead to Israel. The reopening is considered an important step toward ending the war.

Officials say that about 20,000 people need to leave Gaza to seek medical care elsewhere. Many people who left during the war also want to return. At first, about 50 people will be allowed to leave Gaza and 50 people permitted to enter each day. Humanitarian aid enters through other routes.

Egypt will control the crossing on its side, and Israel will control the Gaza side with monitoring by the Palestinian Authority (a governing group) and the European Union (group of 27 nations). People will need approval from Israel or Egypt to cross. Human rights groups have criticized the limit on the number of people who can cross the border.



Penny, the Best in Show winner



WOOF-WORTHY

Wire fox terriers have won 15 Best in Show titles at the Westminster Dog Show, which is the most of any breed.

Winners at Westminster Dog Show

On February 3, Penny, a Doberman pinscher, took home the top prize at the 150th Westminster Kennel Club (WKC) Dog Show in New York City. The 4-year-old became the fifth Doberman to win the title, known as Best in Show, and the first of her breed to win since 1989.

The annual event is the nation's most prestigious dog show. More than 2,500 dogs from 18 countries competed this year. The WKC was established in 1877 and held its first competition that year. It is now the second-longest continuously held sporting event in the US, after the Kentucky Derby horse race.

Dogs are divided into seven groups: herding, hound, non-sporting, sporting, terrier, toy, and working. They are judged on qualities including their appearance and temperament and how

closely they match the ideal for their breed. Each dog has a handler who presents the dog to the judges. The judges select a winner from each group, who then compete for Best in Show.

Penny won in the working group and is "very chill," said her handler, Andy Linton. Cota, a Chesapeake Bay retriever who won in the sporting group, was the runner-up, a first for his breed. Other group winners were Zaida in the hound group, Cookie in the toy group, JJ in the non-sporting group, Graham in the herding group, and Wager in the terrier group.

Linton, who has been showing Dobermans since 1974, won Best in Show at Westminster in 1989 with a dog named Indy. "This is our Super Bowl, this is our NBA Finals, this is all of that," he said. "So to win it, it's just sheer exhilaration."



IT'S AN AMAZING WEEK FOR...

FROZEN FALLS

It's a winter wonder! Temperatures dropped so low that Niagara Falls, the cascading waterfall in New York and Canada, became encased in a layer of ice. Though it looks entirely frozen, the water is still flowing underneath.



Niagara Falls in ice

The lizard



A COLD-WEATHER RESCUE

A tegu lizard found under 20 inches of snow in a Rhode Island driveway is being nursed back to health. The reptiles usually live in warm climates, and it's not clear where this one came from. The "lizard in a blizzard," as it's being called, is recovering. "We have a fighter," rescuers said.

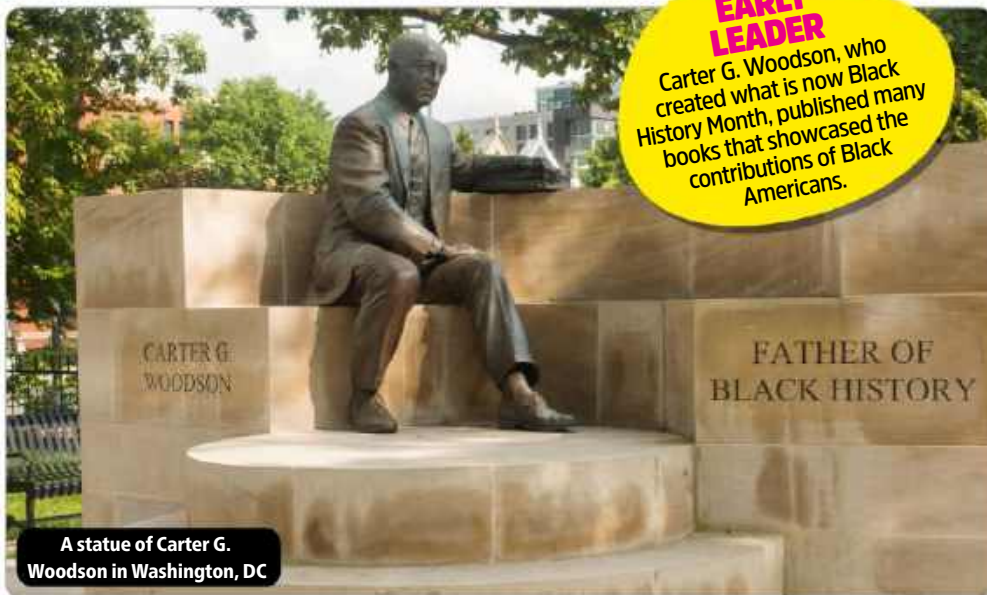
HONORING A LEGEND

The US Postal Service (USPS) is set to release a stamp featuring Bruce Lee, a Chinese American movie star and martial artist. The stamp shows Lee in midair, executing the flying kick he was famous for. Lee, who died in 1973, "inspired a generation of young fans to explore action movies, mixed martial arts, and Asian culture," the USPS said.





National news



EARLY LEADER

Carter G. Woodson, who created what is now Black History Month, published many books that showcased the contributions of Black Americans.

A statue of Carter G. Woodson in Washington, DC

Lawsuit in Philadelphia



After an exhibit honoring the lives of enslaved people at a site in Philadelphia was removed by the National Park Service (NPS), the city filed a lawsuit. It argued that the NPS did not have the authority to remove it and demanded its return. NPS said it was following an executive order from President Donald Trump. The case is ongoing.

Milestone for Black History Month

This February, the US is celebrating the 100th anniversary of Black History Month, an annual event to honor the significant contributions Black Americans have made to the nation.

What is this year's theme?

Every year, the Association for the Study of African American Life and History (ASALH), a nonprofit group, selects the theme. This year's is "A Century of Black History Commemorations," in honor of the anniversary. Organizers said Black History Month has led to discussions about Black history in schools, museums, and other institutions.

How did Black History Month begin?

Carter G. Woodson, who was born in 1875 to formerly enslaved parents, founded the group that

later became the ASALH. In 1926, he established a week to recognize Black Americans, who were often overlooked. He chose dates in February that coincided with the birthdays of Frederick Douglass (1818-1895), a leader of the movement to abolish slavery, and President Abraham Lincoln (1809-1865), who ended slavery. In 1976, President Gerald Ford proclaimed February as Black History Month. In 1986, Congress made the month official.

Why is it significant?

Many US leaders have spoken of the central role of Black people in creating the nation's identity. "Black history is an indispensable part of the American story," Hakeem Jeffries, a top leader in the House of Representatives, said in a statement. John B. King Jr., the head of the State University of

New York, said Black History Month is a time to "reflect on all parts of our nation's history" and "the never-ending mission to achieve justice."

How is it being celebrated?

The Smithsonian's African American History and Culture Museum in Washington, DC, is holding events all month, including a musical production about Black Olympians Jesse Owens and Wilma Rudolph. The Henry Ford museum in Detroit, Michigan, will host a preview of a building where civil rights leaders gathered to plan rallies in the 1960s. The Children's Museum of Atlanta in Georgia will have special activities to help young people find out about Black leaders. When *The Week Junior* went to press, other events and festivities were being planned across the US.



WORD OF THE WEEK

AD

The word "ad" is an abbreviation for "advertisement," which gets its roots from the Latin *advertere*, meaning to "turn toward." That's because an advertisement aims to attract a person's attention and make them "turn toward" the ad with interest.



THE WEEK IN HISTORY

February 14, 1920

League of Women Voters is formed

On February 14, 1920, the League of Women Voters was established. This was six months before the 19th Amendment giving women the right to vote was added to the US Constitution. The league played an active role in encouraging women to vote in local, state, and national elections. Today, the group works to empower all voters to participate in government and to defend democracy.



Members of the League of Women Voters in 1920



New tuition policy set at Yale

Yale University in New Haven, Connecticut, announced a change to its tuition policy. Starting this fall, students whose families have an annual income of less than \$200,000 a year won't have to pay tuition. The full-price cost to attend Yale is more than \$90,000 a year. The policy matches what other top colleges, such as Harvard University, have begun offering. Yale said students from 80% of US households will now qualify for free tuition.



The coin

Native American coin released

The US Mint has released a \$1 coin featuring Polly Cooper, an Oneida woman who aided the US Army during the Revolutionary War (1775-1783). Cooper helped save the lives of starving soldiers by bringing them corn and showing them how to prepare it. The other side of the coin depicts Sacagawea, a Lemhi Shoshone woman who guided the Lewis and Clark expedition in 1804.



Punxsutawney Phil

Groundhog predicts more winter

A groundhog known as Punxsutawney Phil saw his shadow on February 2, Groundhog Day. According to legend, winter weather continues for six weeks if he sees his shadow, and spring weather arrives early if he doesn't. The event, held in Gobbler's Knob, Pennsylvania, began in 1887. Phil's predictions have been accurate about 30% of the time in the last 10 years, according to weather reports.



MUSIC HISTORY

In 2000, the musician Santana became the first Latin American artist to win the Grammy for Album of the Year.

Grammy Awards are presented

On February 1, the most prestigious prizes in music were presented at the 68th annual Grammy Awards. The televised ceremony was held at the Crypto.com Arena in Los Angeles, California, and was hosted by comedian Trevor Noah.

Grammy winners are chosen by nearly 15,000 voting members of the Recording Academy. The awards honor music across multiple genres, including rock, rap, country, and jazz. The four major award categories are Album of the Year, Song of the Year, Record of the Year, and Best New Artist.

History was made when Puerto Rican superstar Bad Bunny won Album of the Year for *Debí Tirar Más Fotos* ("I Should Have Taken More Photos"). It was the first Spanish-language album to win the prize. In his bilingual acceptance speech, Bad Bunny thanked everyone who had believed in him and recognized the resilience of the people of Puerto Rico by saying, "There is nothing we can't achieve."

In other notable wins, singer-songwriter Billie Eilish and her brother Finneas won Song of the Year for "Wildflower." It was their third win in the category—more than any other songwriter has received. Rapper Kendrick Lamar and R&B singer SZA won Record of the Year for the single "luther," which is from Lamar's album *GNX*. Lamar won four other Grammys for *GNX*, bringing his total number of Grammy wins to 27, the most of any rapper in history.

Best New Artist went to British pop singer-songwriter Olivia Dean. The evening also marked the first time a K-pop song was recognized when the award for Best Song Written for Visual Media went to "Golden," from the animated musical *KPop Demon Hunters*.

Musical legend Pharrell Williams received the Dr. Dre Global Impact Award, which honors Black artists for their influence on the industry.

"I've never stopped being a student," he said of his career. "If you do what you love every day, you'll get paid for free."



KPop Demon Hunters

THE WEEK'S SILLIEST HEADLINE

"Kangaroo found hopping loose down Texas road" *UPI*





Around the world



A display of poems at the event

London, United Kingdom **Marking 40 years of subway poetry**

Poets gathered in a subway station on January 30 to mark the 40th anniversary of Poems on the Underground, an initiative to brighten people's commutes with poetry. Since 1986, the project has displayed more than 200 poems as posters inside London Underground train cars, from classic verses by William Shakespeare to recent works by authors like Maya Angelou and Saadi Youssef. Its success inspired programs in cities worldwide.



Laura Fernández

Costa Rica **Next president announced**

Laura Fernández is set to be the new president of Costa Rica. When *The Week Junior* went to press, results were showing that she won the election with more than 48% of the votes. Fernández served as a minister in the government of previous president Rodrigo Chaves. She will be sworn in on May 8 and has promised to be tough on criminals—a stance many voters support after seeing a rise in crime over the past few years.



A registration line

Spain **New rule for migrants**

A plan approved by the government will give about 500,000 people new legal permission to live and work in Spain. Most are economic migrants, who left their home countries to find work, or asylum seekers, who have requested protection from Spain. They must prove that they have lived in the country for more than five months and don't have a criminal record.

The Netherlands **Ruling in climate case**

A court has found that the Dutch government discriminated against the inhabitants of Bonaire, a Dutch territory in the Caribbean, by failing to protect them from the effects of climate change. These include rising sea levels, which could put parts of the island underwater by 2050. The court ordered officials to create a plan to help islanders.



Bonaire



Ivory Coast **Buying more cocoa**

Authorities have launched a new program to help farmers in the Ivory Coast. As global cocoa prices have fallen, exporters have stopped buying local farmers' cocoa beans, which are one of the country's most important crops. Now the nation's Coffee and Cocoa Council will purchase and store surplus beans to ensure that farmers are paid for producing them. The council plans to buy about 100,000 tons of cocoa beans by the end of March.



A cocoa pod

AP (2); ALAMY (3); REUTERS; GETTY IMAGES (4)

Around the world



The potatoes were saved.

Berlin, Germany **A potato giveaway**

A farm in the German state of Saxony had such a bumper crop of potatoes this year that the farmers began giving them away for free. They organized a "potato dump" in Berlin, telling people to help themselves. The team gave spuds to food banks, churches, and schools, hoping to prevent nearly 9 million pounds of potatoes from going to waste.



The park

Tokyo, Japan **World's first Pokémon theme park opens**

A Pokémon-themed amusement park in Tokyo is welcoming its first visitors. PokéPark Kanto covers about 6.4 acres inside the existing theme park Yomiuriland. It features a huge forest filled with more than 600 life-size Pokémon, plus games, interactive experiences, a carousel, and a Pokémon parade. With its grand opening set for February 5, the park is already so popular that tickets have sold out for the next three months.



The toys

China **Sad-faced horse becomes top toy**

A frowning red horse has become a best-selling toy in China. The design was intended as a happy toy for Chinese New Year on February 17 because 2026 is the Year of the Fire Horse in Chinese culture. But the horse's mouth was sewn upside down by mistake, making it look sad. Now sold in both frowning and smiling versions, the toy has gone viral and is seen as an icon for unhappy office workers.

Burkina Faso **Parties dissolved**

The military government in Burkina Faso has banned all 100 political parties in the country. The parties have not been allowed to hold public gatherings since 2022, when military leaders took power. Now they must disband completely. The government claims that the new rules will help bring the country together as part of a plan to rebuild Burkina Faso, but some people feel that this ban is a way to obtain more control.



President Ibrahim Traoré



Military chief Min Aung Hlaing

Myanmar **Election controversy**

The Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP) reportedly won Myanmar's general election. The USDP is backed by the military, which seized power in the country five years ago, sparking an ongoing civil war (conflict between groups within a country). Although the military government insists that the latest election was fair and free, human rights groups say it was not.



The big debate

Is it OK to have ads on school buses?

Some people say there's no harm in it, but others think they're best as ad-free zones.

What you need to know

- Every day in the US, 26 million children ride on 480,000 buses to and from school.
- Some companies pay schools or districts to advertise on their buses.
- According to one estimate by a media company, a school district with 250 buses could make \$1 million in four years by selling ads on buses.
- Ads on school buses are typically age-appropriate, such as for a local business or a community college. Ads for alcohol or tobacco aren't allowed.



FUN FACT
The color most US school buses are painted is called National School Bus Glossy Yellow.

Millions of kids in the US start and end their day with a familiar routine: climbing aboard a yellow school bus and taking a seat. Students have been doing this for decades, but in recent years, the buses have started to look different. Now many of them have colorful advertisements on their exteriors, and some have ads inside as well. Critics say the ride to school should be an ad-free space that is safe from marketing to kids. But others think ads are unavoidable for young people and offer a money-making opportunity for schools to reduce budget shortfalls and improve education for students. What do you think? Is it OK to have ads on school buses?

Yes—they serve a purpose

Ads are everywhere! Kids see them on the street, during YouTube videos, and on the field at major sporting events. There's no avoiding them, so why not make them as kid-friendly as possible? Ads on school buses are a great conversation starter for parents. They can talk to their kids about the goal of paid advertising and how to form their own opinions about it. Plus, school budgets have been cut across the US. Selling ad space on buses provides a source of income that districts and schools can use to hire more teachers, buy musical instruments, or pay for field trips. That's good for students!

No—keep them away from kids

Ads are designed to be persuasive, and studies have shown that children are more susceptible to them, especially under age 8. Some research even shows that ads can negatively affect kids' self-esteem and well-being. A school's job is to help kids learn and look out for their best interests. Are they serving that mission when they put messages from advertisers who are trying to make money in a place where kids can't avoid them? Absolutely not. Besides, ads on bus exteriors are a safety hazard. They can be distracting to drivers who should be paying attention, especially when buses are stopped and kids are getting on and off.

YES Three reasons it's OK to have ads on school buses

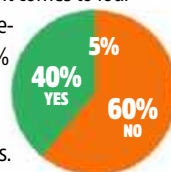
- 1 Ads are everywhere, so seeing them on buses doesn't make a difference.
- 2 They provide a great opportunity for adults to talk to kids about what the advertisers are trying to accomplish.
- 3 Schools need money for classroom supplies and other important things. Ads are a great way to get it.

NO Three reasons it's not OK to have ads on school buses

- 1 Younger people are more easily influenced by ads, and ads can also make kids feel bad about themselves.
- 2 Putting ads on school buses goes against the entire mission of a school.
- 3 Ads on the outside of buses are distracting to other drivers, which can be dangerous for kids.

LAST WEEK'S POLL

Last week, we asked if law enforcement should use robot dogs. When it comes to four-legged crime-fighters, 60% of you said no, while 40% said yes.



What do you think?

Now that you've read a bit more about this issue, visit kids.theweekjunior.com/polls so you can vote in our debate. Vote **YES** if you think it's OK to have ads on school buses or **NO** if you don't. We'll publish the results next week.

The goal of the big debate is to present two sides of an issue fairly in order to stimulate discussion and allow our readers to make up their minds. The views on this page do not reflect those of *The Week Junior*, and the page is not funded by third parties.



A young ice champion

Ilia Malinin is pushing his sport's boundaries all the way to the Olympics.

At age 21, Ilia Malinin has taken the world of figure skating by storm. Nicknamed the "Quad God," he holds the record for the most quadruple jumps (four rotations in the air before landing) in a single program with an astounding seven. Now he will compete on his biggest stage yet at the 2026 Winter Olympics in Italy.

Malinin grew up at the ice rink. His parents, Tatiana Malinin and Roman Skorniakov, are former Olympic figure skaters who competed for Uzbekistan. Raised in Fairfax, Virginia, Malinin said he fell in love with figure skating on his own. "It's such an expressive sport," Malinin told *The Week Junior*. "You're an athlete but also an artist—you can bring emotions and ideas to people with your skating."

In 2019, Malinin made his international debut on the junior circuit, winning the

Philadelphia Summer International. In 2022, at the US International Classic, he became the first skater to land a quadruple axel in competition. Since then, he has won four US national titles (2023–2026), two World Championships (2024 and 2025), and three Grand Prix Final titles (2023–2025).

Malinin said he's honored to be a part of Team USA at the Olympics and looks forward to cheering on his teammates. "My main goal is to have fun and really enjoy it," he said. He also hopes to bring more attention to his sport.

When asked for his advice to young people, Malinin emphasized trust. "One of the most important things is to trust your passion," he said. "If you really want something and put in hard work, you will eventually achieve it."



At the 2026 US Figure Skating Championships



Ilia Malinin

WOW!
Ilia Malinin is the only skater to successfully land all six types of recognized quadruple jumps in competition: the loop, toe loop, salchow, flip, lutz, and axel.

Supporting learning

Alhassan Susso, a teacher at a public high school in the Bronx, New York, recently won a \$25,000 award for excellence in teaching. The recipient of many federal and state teaching awards, he is using the money to support education in his home country, Gambia. Susso, who immigrated to the US as a teen and is legally blind due to an eye disease, is funding a teaching prize and transportation for visually impaired students in Gambia. "People who are disabled can be successful if given proper support," he said.



Alhassan Susso



Zoe Saldana

Actress soars to top

Thanks to her lead role as Neytiri in *Avatar: Fire and Ash*, the third film in the *Avatar* franchise, Zoe Saldana has become the highest-grossing actor of all time. The movie has earned more than \$1.3 billion worldwide since its December premiere. Saldana, the first woman of color to take the top spot, has also played Gamora in Marvel's *Guardians of the Galaxy* trilogy and *Avengers* films. In 2025, she won an Oscar for her supporting role in *Emilia Pérez*, becoming the first Dominican American to do so. She thanked directors and fans, saying, "This accomplishment belongs to all of us."

OVERHEARD



"You have got to stay curious."

Legendary designer Michael Kors on the endurance of his fashion brand, which he founded in 1981



DID YOU KNOW?

A bird's knee joint is hidden underneath its feathers, which makes the bird's legs look shorter than they are.

A red-bellied woodpecker at a feeder

Great Backyard Bird Count to begin

From February 13–16, people worldwide will take part in an annual event called the Great Backyard Bird Count (GBBC). Anyone can participate by counting and identifying birds, then sharing their findings on a website or app.

Since 1998, researchers at the Cornell Lab of Ornithology and the Audubon Society have organized the GBBC to gather data on wild birds. Another organization, Birds Canada, joined the effort in 2009.

During the four-day event, the groups ask bird lovers to become citizen scientists (people who volunteer to collect data for scientific research) by spending at least 15 minutes counting the birds they see in an outdoor area, such as a local park or the yard outside their home. People can participate by creating a free account on the GBBC website, birdcount.org.

For beginning birders, the Merlin Bird ID app can help identify birds. More experienced birdwatchers can also submit observations on eBird, a website and mobile app. A map on the GBBC website lets users watch observations shared in real time from around the world.



Anyone can participate.

Every entry helps researchers learn more about where the birds are, whether their populations are changing, and how to protect them. "Bird observation data is used in a variety of ways to better understand the state of our planet and our natural resources," Becca Rodomsky-Bish, a project co-leader at Cornell, told *The Week Junior*. "Without this data we would have less understanding about what is working, what isn't working, [and] what areas need to be focused on" for conservation.

Last year, more than 800,000 people participated in the GBBC. About 8,078 bird species were identified worldwide, with 670 reported in the US. Birdwatchers in the US and Canada spotted the tufted duck, which is usually found in Africa, Europe, and Asia. Some lucky birdwatchers in Australia caught a glimpse of the Lewin's rail, a hard-to-spot bird with a distinctive call. People in the UK saw the largest flock of birds, reporting 500,000 European starlings in the sky.

The team is excited to see what happens this year. "We anticipate there will always be some new surprises," said Rodomsky-Bish.

Big year for finches



Experts at the Cornell Lab of Ornithology told *The Week Junior* they expect 2026 to be an irruption year. This is when huge numbers of birds move from cold areas like Canada and Alaska to places unusually far south in search of food. Such a "superflight" may take place when a boom of baby birds the previous summer has caused competition for food supplies or when the trees haven't produced enough cones, seeds, and fruit to feed the current bird population. This year, food shortages in Canadian forests seem to be driving seven species of finches into the US. People may spot birds such as the purple finch (shown above), redpoll, and white-winged crossbill in areas where they've never been seen before.



LONG LIVES

Female orcas have been known to live up to 90 years in the wild.



A Pacific white-sided dolphin



An orca

Orcas and dolphins hunt together

Orcas and Pacific white-sided dolphins belong to the same family of animals, but until now they have never been seen acting as a team. For the first time, scientists have observed the marine mammals hunting for a meal together off the coast of British Columbia, Canada.

Orcas, also called killer whales, are top predators in the world's oceans. A group known as the northern residents are often found hunting salmon in the northern Pacific Ocean, which is also the home of Pacific white-sided dolphins. The two species have

often been seen swimming close to each other, but experts didn't know why.

New video and audio revealed that orcas follow the dolphins on dives and that the two take turns making clicking sounds to locate prey. After a successful catch, the dolphins, which can't swallow a whole adult salmon by themselves, enjoy pieces of fish that fall out of the whales' mouths.

Scientists aren't sure how often the animals hunt together, but researcher Sarah Fortune said it's clear that "there was some organization to the chaos."

Animal of the week

Moose



A charity called Rewilding Britain gave two wildlife trusts in the UK about \$20,000 to investigate the idea of returning moose to the wild. The species, known in Europe as the Eurasian elk, vanished from the UK about 2,000 to 3,000 years ago.

- **LIFESPAN:** Up to 25 years
- **HABITAT:** Mainly forests and wetlands
- **SIZE:** About 6 feet tall and 8 to 10 feet long
- **DIET:** Trees, shrubs, herbs, and other plants
- **FUN FACT:** They are very good at swimming and can hold their breath for up to a minute.



Good week / Bad week



African golden cat

Cat conservationists are happy about Uganda's decision to make Echuya Forest Reserve a national park. African golden cats rely on the forest habitat. They'll receive extra protection inside the national park, which could help them thrive.



Glaciers

A study found that thousands of glaciers could disappear every year over the next few decades unless more is done to prevent climate change. Glaciers affect water flow and sea level, and they also cool the planet by reflecting the Sun's rays.



"Why are pink fairy armadillos pink?"

Ashra, 8, California

Mariella Superina

Research scientist, CONICET in Mendoza, Argentina

The thin, bony shell looks pink because blood flows close to its surface. In hot weather, more blood moves through the shell, making it look brighter pink. When it's cold, the blood vessels shrink and less blood flows, so it looks paler. This helps with body temperature control in the desert.



Do you have a question for an animal expert? Send it to hello@theweekjunior.com. Learn more about Dr. Superina's work at xenarthrans.org.



All about the Blue Mosque

An enduring and sacred

Find out about one of the greatest architectural marvels in the world.

The Blue Mosque, a symbol of power and piety, has defined the skyline of Istanbul, Turkey, for more than four centuries.



Inside the mosque

What is the Blue Mosque?

This 17th-century mosque (place of worship for Muslims) gets its name from turquoise tiles that adorn its interior walls. The Blue Mosque is part of a UNESCO World Heritage Site known as the Historic Areas of Istanbul. The site also includes the Hagia Sophia, which was built as a cathedral in the 6th century and is now a mosque, and the Greek Hippodrome, an ancient arena for chariot and horse racing. The Blue Mosque was built during the Ottoman Empire (1299–1922), a Muslim kingdom that ruled for more than 600 years.



A portrait of Ahmed I

How it was built

Local residents refer to the mosque as the Sultan Ahmed Mosque, named after the Ottoman ruler who reigned from 1603–1617. He commissioned the structure when he was 19 years old. Ahmed I wanted his mosque to showcase Ottoman art and architecture and to

rival the grandeur of the Hagia Sophia, located directly across from it. The mosque was considered controversial, as it was built with six minarets as symbols of Islam and the empire's power, at a time when most mosques had no more than four. Under the direction of architect Sedefkar Mehmed Agha, thousands of workers constructed the mosque from 1609 until its opening in 1617.



The Blue Mosque in Istanbul, Turkey

GRAND SCALE
The main building of the Blue Mosque occupies more than 47,000 square feet.

Shades of pink

Other mosques around the world are also known for their striking color. These include several mosques in hues of pink, with each known as “The Pink Mosque.”

One is the Putra Mosque (shown at right), which opened in Putrajaya, Malaysia, in 1999. It is made with rose-tinted granite and blends Malay and Middle Eastern architectural styles.

Another pink mosque is the Dimaukom Mosque in the Philippines, which was built in 2014. Its exterior was painted a shade of bright pink, which is meant to symbolize peace, love, and unity.

The Nasir-al Mulk Mosque in Iran, which opened in 1888, has stained glass windows in geometric designs. In the early morning sun, they cast a kaleidoscopic pattern of vibrant color and light across the rose-tiled prayer hall.



artistic wonder

CAREFULLY CRAFTED

It can take about 70 days to make one Iznik tile, a traditional tile made in the town of Iznik, Turkey.

LIGHT IN MOTION

About 260 stained glass windows in the mosque let in filtered light that appears to dance across the interior.



Architectural features

The Blue Mosque has three entrances, one main dome, and eight smaller domes, which support the weight of the massive central dome. The structure displays perfect symmetry, which represents order and harmony. Among the mosque's most striking features are the approximately 20,000 handmade Iznik tiles that line its prayer hall. The main colors are turquoise, green, red, and white. The designs feature tulips, roses, cypress trees, and other images that carry a symbolic meaning in Islam. One of the greatest calligraphers of the time, Seyyid Kasım Gubarî, inscribed verses from the Quran (holy book of Islam) on the walls inside. The mosque's carved white marble minbar (prayer niche) is positioned so the imam (prayer leader) can be heard by worshippers from anywhere inside the vast hall.



Praying in the mosque

A popular destination

In its more than 400 years of existence, the Blue Mosque has undergone several restorations. The most recent was a five-year project completed in 2023. It included restoring the mosque's signature Iznik tiles and dismantling and rebuilding three minarets that needed structural repair. The mosque continues to be a place of worship and can hold about 10,000 people. Tourists may go inside when prayers are not in session and must follow certain rules and adhere to a dress code. The mosque attracts millions of visitors annually. Its most recent famous guest was Pope Leo XIV, who visited in November.



The Putra Mosque and a view inside





WOW!

The largest coral reef in the world is the Great Barrier Reef in Australia, which covers about 133,000 square miles.



A coral reef in the Red Sea

Coral reefs keep time for ocean life

Scientists have known for years that coral reefs are important to the health of the ocean. Now they have discovered that reefs play an active role as daily timekeepers that shape the routines of the microbes around them. Microbes are living things, like bacteria and algae, that are so small they can't be seen by humans without a microscope.

Corals look like plants, but they are actually made up of thousands of individual animals called polyps. Each polyp has a stomach, mouth, and tentacles. When corals attach themselves to hard surfaces, they grow and expand to form reefs. These reefs create an ecosystem (group of plants and animals that affect one another), providing food and shelter to microscopic creatures and large animals like sharks and sea turtles.

In a new study, scientists studied the waters above coral reefs in the Gulf of Aqaba in the Red Sea, in the Middle East. Researchers monitored the area continuously, day and night. They collected water samples every six hours in summer and winter and compared what they found with samples from nearby open ocean waters.

The team found that overall, there were consistently fewer microbes near reefs than

there were in open waters. Researchers detected 20% to 60% fewer bacteria and up to 75% fewer micro-algae in reef water.

But the microbes that are near reefs followed a tight daily schedule. For example, by midday, there was a spike in the number of single-cell organisms that live inside corals and produce food for them. The scientists think this change is linked to sunlight and how the corals eat.

And after sunset, the number of organisms that feed on bacteria increased by approximately 80%. Scientists think this spike is likely connected to these predators' eating cycles, which keep the number of microbes in check.

Daily changes in microbes were greater than seasonal changes between summer and

winter. "The reef is not just passively surrounded by microbes," said Miguel J. Frada, a lead author of the study. "It actively structures microbial life in time, creating daily patterns that repeat across seasons and influence how energy and nutrients move through the ecosystem."

Knowing the routines that coral reefs follow can help scientists look for early signs that they're under stress from warming waters, pollution, or other effects of climate change.



A map of the region

The next generation



Some of the baby corals

The Florida Aquarium, located in Tampa, has grown about 9,000 coral babies in its Coral Conservation and Research Center. The baby corals, which have been growing at the center for seven months, are part of an initiative to restore 25% of the state's coral reefs by 2050. Nearly 90% of Florida's coral reefs have been wiped out in recent years.

The baby corals were sent to two nonprofits in the state, Reef Renewal USA and the Reef Institute, where they will keep growing. Their progress will be monitored to make sure they remain healthy and resilient. Then, later this year, they will be transported to the Florida Keys and Palm Beach areas, where they will be planted on existing reefs. Scientists will observe how the plants survive and cope with challenges like heat and disease.



Traces of da Vinci's DNA may have been found

Scientists said they have found a sample of DNA (chemical that carries information about a living thing) that may belong to the famous artist and scientist Leonardo da Vinci.

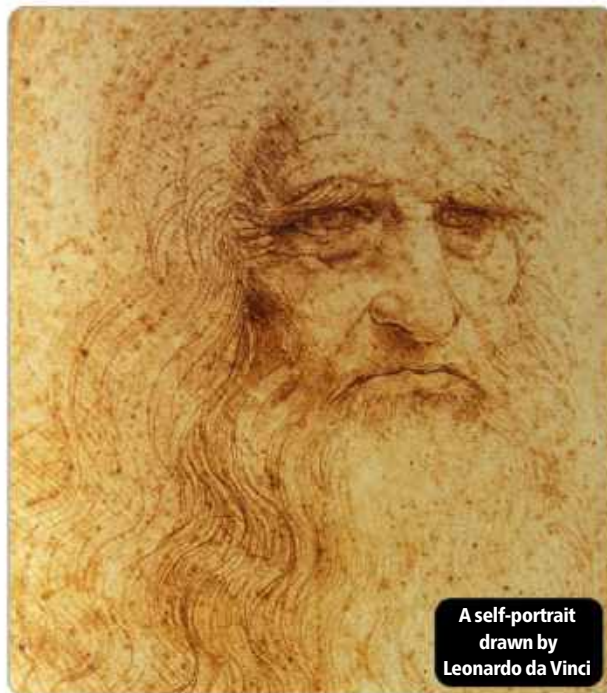
A person's DNA can be found in objects they have touched, and DNA in people who are related to each other has similarities. This sample was taken from a sketch called *Holy Child* that da Vinci may have drawn. The DNA was similar to a sample taken from a letter written by a relative of his. Both samples came from people who likely had an ancestor in Tuscany, where he was born.

However, experts aren't certain whether *Holy Child* was drawn by da Vinci or one of his students. Even if da Vinci drew it, the DNA could have come

from people who handled the drawing over the years. The scientists who collected the sample hope to gain access to more of da Vinci's works so they can look for more potential DNA.

Da Vinci's DNA could offer clues to his genius. For example, some historians believe he had unusually good vision. Studying his DNA could reveal a genetic trait that gave him exceptional eyesight and support the theory that this quality was key to his work.

The DNA could also have historical value. Da Vinci is buried in France, but there is debate over whether the remains are his. A confirmed sample of his DNA would settle that question. It could also be used to confirm whether other artworks were created by him.



A self-portrait drawn by Leonardo da Vinci

RARE TREASURES
There are fewer than 20 surviving paintings confirmed to have been created by Leonardo da Vinci.

A China Eastern Airlines jet



Longest passenger flight takes off

The world's longest passenger flight took off for the first time, covering 12,200 miles over 29 hours. The China Eastern Airlines journey began in Shanghai, China, and ended in Buenos Aires, Argentina. A two-hour stopover in Auckland, New Zealand, halfway through allowed for refueling and a change of staff.

The airline will fly the route twice a week. There are more than 55,000 Chinese people who live in Argentina, and the new flight will

serve this fast-growing community. China Eastern Airlines said the route "fills the gap in direct flights" between Shanghai and other large cities in South America.

The longest nonstop flight is between Singapore and New York, which is a 19-hour journey run by Singapore Airlines. An airline called Qantas aims to launch a nonstop flight between Sydney, Australia, and London, England, in 2027. It is expected to take about 22 hours.



Eyeglasses that focus themselves

The IXI glasses, with the technology visible on one side



Researchers in Finland are developing eyeglasses that automatically sharpen focus based on a person's eye movements. The IXI glasses, which look like a regular pair, use liquid-crystal technology.

When a user puts on the IXI glasses, sensors inside the

frames track the movement of their eyes. When they look at something up close, the sensors send a small electric pulse to the crystals, which rearrange themselves to let the person see better. When the wearer looks far away again, the lenses adjust back to distance vision.



Elena Rybakina

WARM WELCOME
The Australian Open is nicknamed the "Happy Slam" because of its festive, friendly atmosphere.



Carlos Alcaraz

A tennis legend



Margaret Court (above) is an Australian who dominated women's tennis in the 1960s and early 1970s. She and Novak Djokovic share the all-time record for the most Grand Slam singles titles—24. She won 64 major titles across singles, doubles, and mixed doubles.

Rybakina, Alcaraz win Australian Open

The 2026 Australian Open, one of the four most important international tennis tournaments of the year, known as Grand Slams, ended on February 1. The women's singles champion was Elena Rybakina of Kazakhstan, who won her first Australian Open title. The men's singles champion was Carlos Alcaraz of Spain. It was also the first time he won the tournament. He has now won all four Grand Slam tournaments over the course of his career and, at the age of 22, is the youngest player to ever accomplish that feat.

The women's singles final was played on January 31. Rybakina, who was seeded (ranked) fifth, beat the number one seed, Aryna Sabalenka of Belarus, 6–4, 4–6, 6–4. Coming into the

match, neither of the two players had lost a single set during the tournament, something that had not happened in a women's Grand Slam final in 18 years. The final was a rematch of the 2023 Australian Open, which Sabalenka won.



Novak Djokovic

This year's final was highly competitive. Rybakina took control early, winning the opening set, but Sabalenka stayed composed and won the second set. Sabalenka continued her strong play early in the third set. She won the first three games and appeared on her way to another Australian Open title. But

Rybakina mounted a comeback, winning five consecutive games to regain control. She served for the championship and secured the win with an ace (a serve that an opponent does not hit back).

In the men's final, Alcaraz, the number one seed, beat fourth-seeded Novak Djokovic of Serbia, 2–6, 6–2, 6–3, 7–5. Djokovic entered the match with an opportunity to win his 25th Grand Slam title, which would have set a record for the most by any player in the sport's history. It was the first time he had made an Australian Open final and lost.

Djokovic got off to a strong start, but Alcaraz came back and demonstrated why he is the top men's player in the world, winning the second and third sets comfortably. Djokovic battled admirably in the fourth set, but Alcaraz was too much to handle. He has now won seven Grand Slam titles.

Although no American players made the singles final this year, the US still had success at the tournament. Ben Shelton, Learner Tien, Coco Gauff, Pegula, Iva Jovic, and Amanda Anisimova all reached the quarterfinals.

THIS WEEK'S WINNERS...

BASKETBALL

The Charlotte Hornets beat the Dallas Mavericks, 123–121, on January 29 in a matchup featuring star rookies and former college teammates Kon Knueppel, age 20, and Cooper Flagg, age 19. Knueppel, who plays for the Hornets, scored the game-winning free throws and had a career-high 34 points. Flagg, who plays for the Mavericks, scored 49 points, the most ever by a teenager in the NBA.



Nelly Korda

TRACK AND FIELD

At the John Thomas Terrier Classic in Boston, Massachusetts, on January 31, Sam Ruthe, a 16-year-old from New Zealand, ran a mile in 3:48.88 minutes, setting a new world record for the fastest mile by a runner under 18.

GOLF

US star Nelly Korda was named the winner of the LPGA Tournament of Champions on February 1 after the competition was cut short due to weather. It was her first win since 2024.



WOW!

In January, 30 NHL players scored at least three goals in a game, a new league record for a month.



Patrick Kane (left)

History-filled week in the NHL

A thrilling few days in the NHL (National Hockey League) kicked off on January 29. One major US record fell, and two special games delivered extra excitement.

History was made on the 29th when Patrick Kane of the Detroit Red Wings recorded an assist in a game against the Washington Capitals, which gave him an NHL career total of 1,375 points (goals plus assists). He is now the highest-scoring US-born athlete to play in the league. He broke a record that former NHL star Mike Modano held for more than 18 years. Earlier in the month, Kane, who grew up in Buffalo, New York, became the fifth US-born player to score 500 NHL goals.

The same night Kane made history, the Colorado Avalanche visited the Montreal Canadiens for a game with a fun twist. Before

moving to Colorado in 1995, the Avalanche were the Quebec Nordiques. They used to play a rivalry game against the Canadiens known as the "Battle of Quebec." The theme was revived for the January 29 game, with the league-leading Avalanche wearing Nordiques throwback jerseys. Montreal ended up winning, 7–3.

On February 1, the Boston Bruins and Tampa Bay Lightning faced off in one of the NHL's Stadium Series games, which are played outdoors. The Lightning's Brandon Hagel scored 11 seconds into the game, but the Bruins came back with five straight goals. The game was tied by the Lightning in the third period and eventually went to overtime and a penalty shootout. Lightning forward Jake Guentzel scored the lone goal of the shootout for the largest comeback win in Lightning history.



COACH OF THE WEEK

Coach's name: **Angel Martinez, Jr.**

Team: **Washington Nationals (Little League baseball)**

"Coach Angel always wants us to succeed. Sometimes he seems strict, but he's just pushing us to do our best. He's always cheering us on, and whether we're winning or losing, he's always proud of us. Coach Angel helped me improve my swing by teaching me mechanics and having me practice over and over. Thanks to his great coaching and encouragement, we won the league championship! I wish he could always be my coach." Oliver, Washington, DC, 11



To nominate a Coach of the Week, send your coach's name, photo, sport, and team to hello@theweekjunior.com. Include your name, age, state, and a few reasons why your coach is great.

SPOTLIGHT ON...



Dylanne Free

AGE: 17 SPORT: SKIJORING
TEAM: FREERIDE MONTANA

Getting started Skijoring is a timed skiing event where one skier navigates a course with gates—similar to ski racing—while being pulled by a rider on a horse. The skier who completes the course cleanly with the fastest time wins. I'm a rider and compete on a team with my family. One of my most exciting moments was pulling my brother in a race and winning by milliseconds.

Role models

I competed in gymnastics for about 14 years. Simone Biles and Gabby Douglas inspired me with their work ethic, confidence, and resilience.



Training plan

I keep my skijoring horses in shape by riding six to seven days a week. Our practices include guiding and turning drills, dragging heavy objects like logs or sleds filled with dirt, and when there's snow, building tracks and running them several times a week.

Calming trick One way I take care of my mental health is by spending intentional alone time with my horses. Horses have a way of bringing you into a different version of yourself and reconnecting you with nature and your surroundings.

Major focus My race preparation always starts with my horses. They come first—always. They eat before I do, have full buckets of water all day, and receive chiropractic work and massages before and after races. Their well-being is non-negotiable. If something isn't safe for them, it isn't worth the belt buckle prize, the time, or the applause.

Wise words Doubt doesn't decide your future. Work does. Passion does. Grit does.



Arts and entertainment



New movie from an NBA star

Steph Curry produced and acts in *GOAT*, which is loosely inspired by his life.

The average height of players in the NBA (National Basketball Association) is 6-foot-7, and several are more than 7 feet tall. Golden State Warriors star Steph Curry is 6-foot-2, but he's still found massive success on the basketball court. Among his achievements are four NBA championships, two NBA Most Valuable Player awards, and the league record for the most three-pointers made. NBA legend LeBron James considers Curry the greatest of all time — also known as the GOAT — when it comes to shooting.

Now Curry's production company is bringing *GOAT*, an animated film loosely inspired by his life, to the big screen. The action-comedy, which arrives in theaters on February 13, is set in a magical animal-filled world. It follows Will (voiced by Caleb McLaughlin of *Stranger Things*), a small and talented goat who wants to play roarball, a sport filled with much bigger players. In addition to producing the film, Curry voices Lenny, an 11-foot-tall giraffe and the tallest player in the roarball league.

Curry told *The Week Junior* he related to Will, who is overlooked and underestimated but remains motivated and never quits. "Just like Will, I never gave up on my dreams, working really

hard and believing in myself, even when the going got tough," Curry said.

Working as a voice actor was a fun challenge for the star. "As an athlete, I'm used to expressing myself through movement and the game itself," he said. "But in the recording booth, all you have is your voice." It took him time to get used to the experience and figure out how to convey all of Lenny's emotions, but he found that exciting.

"Audiences will be able to hear a bit of my personality in Lenny, which I think is awesome," he said.

When Curry and his team were creating the film, they had several goals. One was to have kids "see themselves in Will" and know "they have the power to rise up and achieve something incredible," he said. The team also wanted to show that being great isn't

just a title but part of a journey that involves believing in yourself even if other people don't. "Greatness also isn't just about being the biggest, the fastest, or the most wanted right away," he said. "Never let anyone tell you what you can't do!"

Curry hopes kids who see the film will come away inspired. "The biggest lesson in *GOAT*," he said, "is that being underestimated doesn't define you. What defines you is how you respond to it."



Steph Curry

The making of roarball



Roarball, the sport in *GOAT*, is a full-contact co-ed sport that mixes basketball with the intensity of hockey. The animal players can handle the ball with different parts of their bodies, including horns, tongues, and tails. It is played on a court that is the size of a soccer field, and every team's stadium has a special feature, such as being on top of an active volcano or having sandstorms roll through.

The roarball players were designed to move like human athletes, including "the way they warm up, handle the ball, and even walk onto the court," Steph Curry said. NBA fans may notice that Will shoots just like Curry in real life. Another roarball player uses the "shake and bake," a signature move of former NBA star Jamal Crawford. Former NBA star Andre Iguodala created plays that the roarball teams use on the court.



Miraculous stage show announced

Next year, fans of the series *Miraculous: Tales of Ladybug & Cat Noir* will be able to see their favorite heroes brought to life. A new stage production is in the works and set to tour in 2027. It will feature acrobatics, aerial stunts, illusions, dance, puppetry, and interactive video.

Miraculous premiered in 2015 and was originally a French animated series. The English version arrived in the US the same year. The show follows teen friends Marinette Dupain-Cheng and Adrien Agreste, whose alter egos are superheroes Ladybug and Cat Noir. Using their powers, they protect Paris from the villain Hawk Moth. Despite their close relationship in their regular lives, they keep their true identities secret from each other in hero mode. There have been six seasons of the show and a Netflix film. A film that will be released in movie theaters is in the works.

An all-new *Miraculous* story is being developed for the stage production, which will also have a new villain and original music. Ella Louise Allaire, one of the creators of the live show, told *Variety* the goal is to “honor these extraordinary characters and celebrate the world.” She said she was inspired by Marinette, in particular. “She’s bright, athletic, and creative—we need more heroes like Ladybug and Cat Noir for families and for this generation of boys and girls.”

Allaire’s partner, Martin Lord Ferguson, also told *Variety* that thanks to theatrical craft and technology, the *Miraculous* stage show will “deliver moments you can’t get on a screen.” He said it is “crafted like a pop concert, paced like an action film, and grounded in a fairy tale, where courage is contagious.”

GLOBAL SENSATION
Miraculous: Tales of Ladybug & Cat Noir reaches audiences in more than 150 countries.



3 MORE PICKS TO ENJOY THIS WEEK



CLICK: MYWILDBACKYARD

On this YouTube channel, biologist Spencer Hoffman explores the hidden worlds of backyard creatures. Videos follow him tracking king cobras, testing centipede venom, and investigating deadly spiders. In the process, he reveals the strange and surprising ways animals survive and thrive. (youtube.com/@MyWildBackyard)



PLAY: NETFLIX PARTY GAMES

Netflix now lets you play games on your TV using your phone as a controller. Friends and family can play together in party games such as Pictionary: Game Night, Lego Party, and Tetris Time Warp, while mobile games such as Barbie Color Creations and Toca Boca Hair Salon 4 can be played solo. (Netflix)



WATCH: COSMIC PRINCESS KAGUYA!

This new animated film is inspired by a Japanese folktale. It follows a teen who is a fan of the online virtual world Tsukuyomi, where users perform and stream as digital avatars. She discovers a mysterious baby who grows into a girl her age and helps her explore Tsukuyomi. (Netflix)



READER RECOMMENDS



Ne Zha and Ne Zha 2 PG-13 (HBO Max or rent on other platforms)

“The energy of these films is thrilling, combining powerful life lessons with breathtaking adventure. The story centers on a magical object, the Chaos Pearl, which a great god and his disciples split into the Spirit Pearl and the Demon Pill. A boy named Ne Zha was supposed to get the Spirit Pearl, but he ends up with the Demon Pill instead. As a result, the villagers fear him, and he struggles against their prejudice and his own demon destiny. In the two films, he finds ways to prove he can choose his own fate. There are surprising friendships, intense battles, and strong moral themes.” Dhruv, 11, Ohio

Do you have a film or TV show to recommend to other kids? Send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.



Book club

THIS WEEK'S BOOK

A Tale of Plagues and Perfumes

By Jake Halpern and Peter Kujawinski

Nia, a 12-year-old orphan, has spent most of her life trying to survive in Yerat, a land with a history of deadly plagues. She thought things were looking up after her aunt took her in, but a ship has come into port carrying a new contagious disease. Nia possesses the incredible power to smell and identify the faintest odors—she can even see scents as colors. As the fast-spreading plague begins, she is tapped to join the Cloister, a society of gifted individuals known as Sinsories who possess extraordinary senses, led by the Great Mother. Some there hope Nia can use her abilities to concoct a “curefume,” an antidote to the terrifying plague. Unfortunately, not everyone at the Cloister wants her to succeed. Nia will have to escape from the Sinsories’ strange tower, avoid the lizard-like Ravagers, and risk exposing herself to the plague. She’ll need all the help she can get from Lime, who has tremendous taste buds, and Lowe, whose touch can absorb the memories of those he meets. The co-authors use humor about side effects from the trio’s heightened senses to lighten the perilous plot. Ages 8–12

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS FOR YOUR BOOK CLUB

What do you think are the pros and cons of having enhanced senses?

Do the people of Yerat have any justification to fear the Sinsories? Explain.

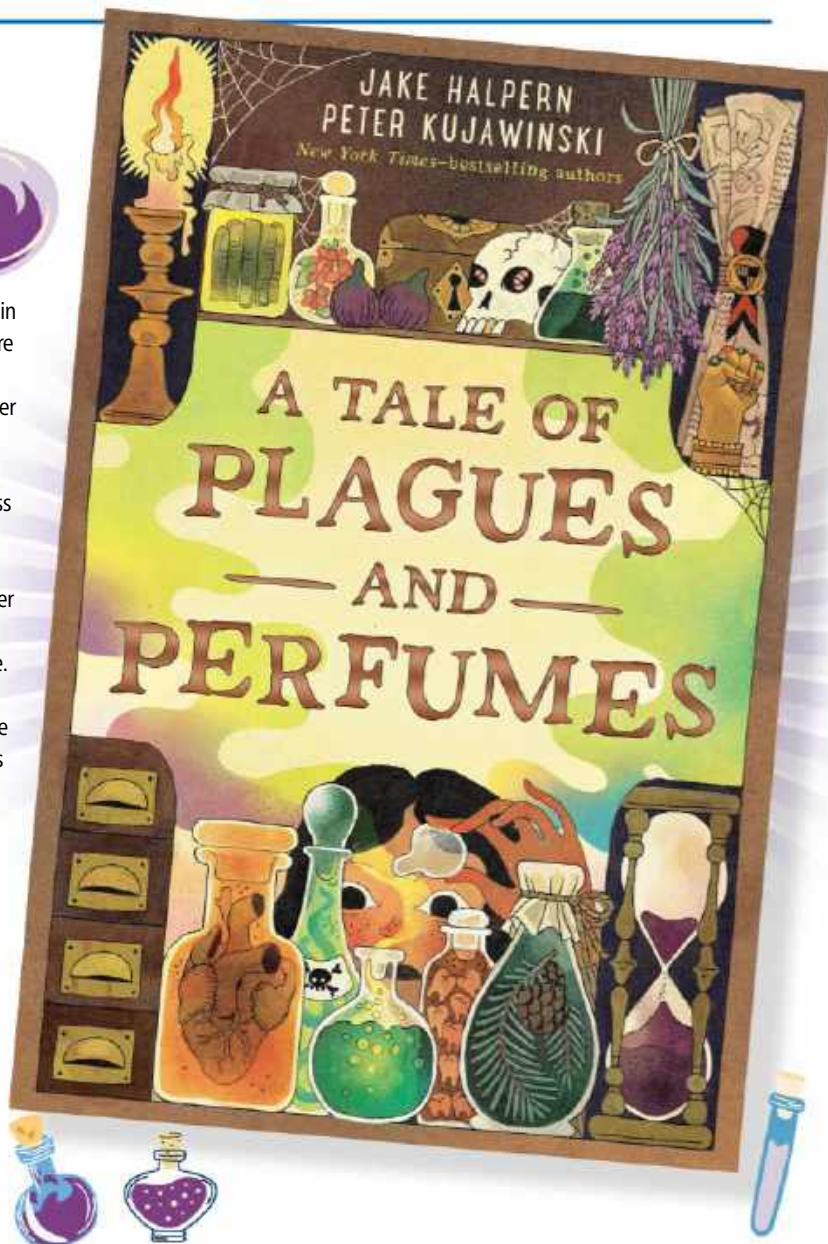
Do you see any real-world comparisons between the plague in the story and the COVID-19 pandemic?

What appears to motivate the Great Mother’s actions?

Do the protocols used by the citizens to avoid the plague have any scientific basis? Why or why not?

Which character would you want most as a friend?

If you could enhance one sense, which would it be?



Find your next great read

If you liked...



Escape from Mr. Lemoncello's Library

By Chris Grabenstein

When 12 kids get locked in a new high-tech library, they must use clues, puzzles, and riddles from the books to figure out their escape route and win a wondrous prize. Readers can play along with the characters.

You might like...



The Gollywhopper Games

By Jody Feldman

A group of children have been training for months to participate in the Gollywhopper Games, a fierce competition hosted by a toy company. Each round brings harder puzzles, brainteasers, mazes, and other games readers can solve. Ages 8–12



Guess the book this quote comes from

“Never do anything by halves if you want to get away with it. Be outrageous. Go the whole hog.”

Hint: This classic book was made into a hit Broadway musical, with rebellious songs like “Naughty” and “Revolting Children.”

Answer: *Matilda* by Roald Dahl. The spunky title character gives this advice to her classmate about how to handle their mean-spirited teacher.



THIS WEEK'S AUTHOR

Peter Kujawinski

Peter Kujawinski is an award-winning and best-selling author of numerous adventure and fantasy books for children and young adults. He often works with his writing partner of 20 years, Jake Halpern. Together, they wrote the *Dormia* trilogy, a fantasy series following a 12-year-old boy who learns he must save a secret world.

What inspired your new book?

My writing partner Jake and I have both observed that animals have an incredible sense of smell. For example, I was taking my dog for a walk, and she just stopped and was sniffing, like something incredible was around the corner. Jake and I wondered about people who may have excellent senses. What would that be like for them?

Did any time period or historical event influence this book?

We were researching famous plagues in history, then COVID hit while we were working on this book. So that ended up influencing the story quite a bit.

Did any real cities inspire Yerat?

I was lucky enough to go on a backpacking trip in Syria many years ago. I visited a city in the north called Aleppo. I remember being transfixed by its rich, diverse culture. There's



also something about port cities, like Marseille, France, that is very intriguing.

What are your favorite things about working with a writing partner?

It is so fun to write with someone who shares your excitement about a cool plot development or character arc. You've got somebody to share in the great moments and the stressful ones. It's wonderful to go through the life of a book with someone.

What books did you enjoy as a child?

Stories that were similar to the kind I write now. I received a box set of *The Chronicles of Narnia* from my grandfather, and I just dove into that world.

You live in Chicago. White Sox or Cubs?

Cubs. I grew up in the 1980s, when they always came so close to success. We fans still have trauma!



3 books to celebrate Lunar New Year

The holiday begins on February 17. Get in the spirit with one of these stories.



Ling & Ting's Lunar New Year

By Grace Lin

Chinese American twins Ling and Ting plan to ring in Lunar New Year by decorating, eating

oranges, and wearing costumes. But when they do something that may make the year unlucky, they have to fix it. Illustrations and information about the holiday's traditions and symbols make this short book, the fifth in the *Ling & Ting* series, delightful to read. Ages 6–9



Mindy Kim and the Lunar New Year Parade

By Lyla Lee, illustrated by Dung Ho

It's 7-year-old Mindy's first Lunar New Year

without her mom, who has passed away. Mindy keeps up her traditions, like making rice cake soup, a Korean favorite, while starting new traditions with her dad and friends. This story is the second in the 12-book *Mindy Kim* series. Ages 7–10



What Is Lunar New Year?

By Vivian Jun Kirklin, illustrated by Gregory Copeland

This nonfiction book explains the origins of

Lunar New Year and how it's commemorated by Asian communities around the world. You'll learn about the history of the famous Chinese New Year Parade and Festival in San Francisco, California, which is the biggest Lunar New Year parade outside China. Ages 8–12



Reader recommends

Best Nerds Forever

By James Patterson and Chris Grabenstein

"This story is about a middle schooler named Finn who dies by accidentally biking off a cliff. As a ghost, Finn has unfinished business to take care of before he can move on to the afterlife. He meets other ghosts who also have matters that are outstanding. One of those ghosts is named Isabella. Finn helps Isabella complete what she has to do. This book has a happy ending. It almost made me cry!" Anna, 11, New York City

Do you have a book to recommend? We want to hear about it! With an adult's help, please send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.



Find out more about *The Week Junior* Book Club and check out our previous titles at kids.theweekjunior.com/bookclub.





How to...

Celebrate Valentine's Day!

Get ready to make the people you care about feel special on February 14.

Valentine's Day is a holiday that traditionally celebrates love and may date back more than 1,000 years. Today, it honors many kinds of relationships that bring people happiness. Here are a few ways to spread joy to the important people in your life.

Plan a small surprise

February 14 is on a Saturday this year. With the day off from school, you may have plenty of time to offer a sweet surprise or two. For example, you can bring a parent their morning juice and a pastry in bed or make them a photo slideshow of some of your favorite memories together. You could also create a homemade card (see the craft instructions for papercut valentines on the opposite page).

Add festive touches to your home

Cut paper hearts out of construction paper, punch holes in them, and use string to hang the hearts across a mantel or a bookcase. If you have streamers left over from a previous party, hang

them around your living room. Another idea is to cut out paper hearts and add uplifting messages to them, such as "Looking good!" or "You make my heart happy." Then leave them in fun places, like inside a closet door, on a bathroom mirror, or taped to the refrigerator.



Spend time together

One of the most thoughtful ways to show someone you care is to set aside special time for the two of you. That could be taking a hike with a parent, enjoying a movie night with a sibling or friend, or sharing a sweet treat or video call with a grandparent.

Make homemade treats

Valentine's Day is closely associated with chocolate and candy. Consider making some for the special people in your life. Check out the recipes for strawberry fudge and jam thumbprint cookies on these pages. When you share your homemade goods, consider including a brief note to the recipient about why you appreciate them!

**OH,
FUDGE!**

The largest slab of fudge ever made was in Ontario, Canada, in 2010 and weighed 5,760 pounds.

WARNING!

Ask an adult's permission before using a mixer, stove, or oven.

Strawberry fudge

Ingredients

- 16 ounces white chocolate chips or chopped white chocolate
- 1 (14-ounce) can sweetened condensed milk
- 3 tablespoons butter
- ½ teaspoon vanilla
- 2 teaspoons strawberry Jell-O powder
- Kosher salt
- 1 (1-ounce) package freeze-dried strawberries

Instructions

1. Line an 8-inch square baking pan with parchment paper.
2. With an adult's help, combine the chocolate, condensed milk, butter, vanilla, Jell-O powder, and a few pinches of salt in a medium saucepan over low heat. Melt, stirring frequently, until the mixture is smooth.
3. Set aside ¼ cup of the strawberries and crush the remaining. Immediately fold in the crushed strawberries, then pour the mixture into the prepared pan. Smooth the top, then press on the remaining strawberries, breaking them into bits.
4. Transfer the fudge to the refrigerator and chill until set, about 1 hour. To serve, remove the candy from the parchment and cut into 1- to 2-inch pieces. Makes about 3 dozen pieces.



Jam thumbprint cookies

Ingredients

- 1¾ cups all-purpose flour
- ¼ teaspoon baking powder
- ½ teaspoon kosher salt
- ¾ (1½ sticks) cup unsalted butter, softened to room temperature
- ¾ cup sugar
- 1 egg, at room temperature
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- ½ cup raspberry or strawberry jam

Instructions

1. Heat oven to 350° F and line two baking sheets with parchment paper.
2. In a small bowl, whisk together the flour, baking powder, and salt.
3. In a stand mixer fitted with a paddle attachment and set at medium speed, beat the butter and sugar until light and fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the egg and vanilla and beat to incorporate. Reduce the mixer's speed to low and blend in the flour mixture ⅓ at a time.
4. Scoop a level tablespoon of the dough and roll it into a ball. Repeat with the remaining dough, spacing the balls 2 inches apart on the prepared sheets.
5. Make two indentations with your thumb, pinky, or the back of a small oval measuring

SHARE THE LOVE!

If you make anything on these pages, ask an adult to email a photo and a quote to hello@theweekjunior.com.

spoon in each ball of dough to form a V, pressing deep enough to create a heart-shaped well. Take care to leave a little extra space around the edges.

6. Once the cookies are pressed, drop and spread ½ teaspoon of jam into the heart-shaped divot you made.
7. Bake the cookies until light golden around the edges, about 6 minutes. Transfer the cookies to a rack to cool completely. Makes about 2 dozen cookies.



Papercut valentines

What you'll need

- Thin colored papers such as origami paper, wrapping paper scraps, or recycled papers such as newspapers, magazines, or sheet music
- Pencil
- Scissors
- Edging scissors such as pinking shears or scalloped scissors (optional)
- Hole punch (optional)

Instructions

1. Make a basic heart: Fold a piece of paper in half. Draw half a heart with its center along the folded edge, then cut it out.
2. Next, add cut decorations. Before opening the heart, cut small half-shapes along the folded edge to create symmetrical images (such as half a mouth and nose or half a butterfly). You

can use a hole punch to add eyes if you like, also before opening the heart.

3. Try more elaborate designs. Experiment with additional folds to create more places to cut. You can accordion-fold the heart, add a fold perpendicular to the center fold, or add diagonal folds. Cut half-shapes along any folded edges.

4. Open your heart to see your design. If you'd like to add more details, refold the heart and make additional cuts.

5. For each valentine, apply glue to the back of the heart and attach it to a piece of paper in another color. Cut around the heart, leaving a border of contrasting color. Write a message on the back!



Revolutionary Williamsburg

Did you know that Williamsburg was once full of people with big ideas? In the 1700s, important leaders lived, worked, and shared ideas here that helped start a new country. As we celebrate 250 years of American independence, let's play a fun matching game and meet the people who helped shape the United States.

SNAP QUIZ

WHO'S WHO?

People in Williamsburg helped change history!

Can you guess who is who?
Circle the right answer.

1. WHO AM I?



Who led the Continental Army in the Revolutionary War and became the first president of the United States?

- A** George Washington
- B** Thomas Jefferson
- C** James Madison

2. WHO AM I?



Who was the primary author for the Declaration of Independence and later became our third president?

- A** James Monroe
- B** Thomas Jefferson
- C** Patrick Henry

3. WHO AM I?



Who gave powerful speeches in Williamsburg about liberty and freedom?

- A** Alexander Hamilton
- B** Patrick Henry
- C** James Madison

4. WHO AM I?



Who studied in Williamsburg and later helped write the U.S. Constitution?

- A** James Madison
- B** George Washington
- C** James Monroe

5. WHO AM I?



Who studied and worked in Williamsburg and later became president of the United States?

- A** Thomas Jefferson
- B** Alexander Hamilton
- C** James Monroe

6. WHO AM I?



Who fought with George Washington's army in the Battle of Yorktown and later inspired a famous musical?

- A** Patrick Henry
- B** Alexander Hamilton
- C** James Madison

Want to learn even more?

Visit Williamsburg to walk the same streets, see the buildings, and discover the stories of the people who helped shape our country. History comes to life when you explore it in person!





Puzzles



Crisscross

Each of these words associated with eyes fits into this grid. Can you find where each one goes to complete the grid?

3 letters

SEE

4 letters

BLUE

SHUT

VIEW

5 letters

BROWN

HAZEL

VISOR

6 letters

RETINA

7 letters

EYELIDS

MONOCLE

STARING

8 letters

DILATION

9 letters

EYELASHES

10 letters

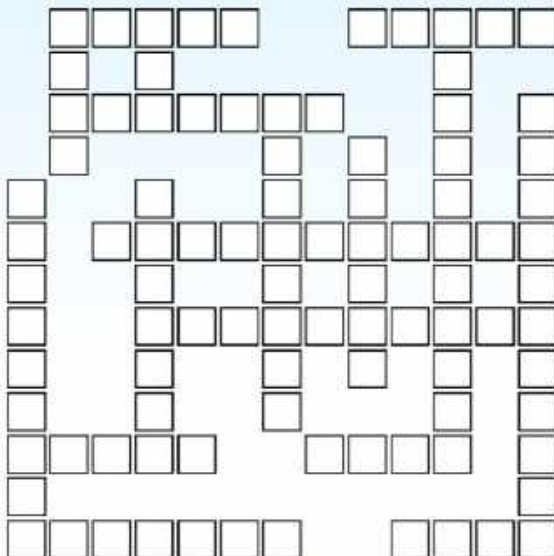
OPTIC NERVE

11 letters

CONTACT LENS

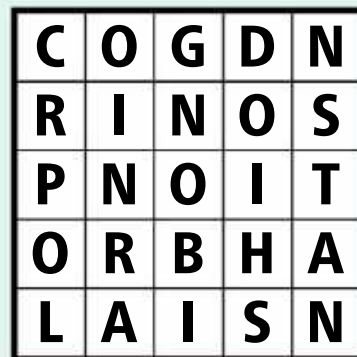
OPTOMETRIST

PERSPECTIVE



Take five

Five 5-letter words that can follow the word RED to make a familiar phrase are hidden in this grid. For each one, the first letter is somewhere in the first column, the second is somewhere in the second column, and so on. Can you find all five?



ALL THE SAME

Each answer contains the letters L-O-V-E. Those letters have been placed for you. Can you figure out the words? (NEED A HINT? Check the bottom of the page.)

1. Three-leaf plant also called a shamrock

LOVE

2. Cozy sofa for two people

LOVE

3. Small storage spot in a car's dashboard

LOVE

4. Sweater you put on by putting your head through the neck

LOVE

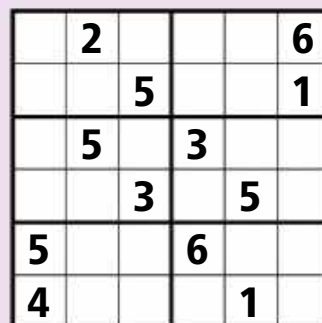
5. Having an untidy appearance

LOVE

ANSWERS
CAN BE
FOUND ON
PAGE 29.

SUDOKU

To complete the grid, place the numbers from 1 to 6 exactly once in each row, column, and 2x3 bold-lined box.



Spot the difference

These two pictures of Valentine's Day hearts appear to be the same, but take a closer look. There are actually five differences. Can you see them?





What an eye-dea!



Seeing is believing in Boston

Visitors to downtown Boston, Massachusetts, should be on the lookout for some eye-popping art this winter. For an installation called "Big Other," artists Pierre&Marie placed giant eyes on six buildings across the city, including a hotel, a skyscraper, and a bookstore. It's part of the third annual WINTERACTIVE, a free, walkable, outdoor art exhibition. Pierre&Marie said "Big Other" is meant to give someone the feeling of being watched, mirroring the relationship people have with social media.

Rock 'n' rolling along



A train filled with Elvis Presleys

Fans all over the world still remember the singer Elvis Presley (1935–1977), who was famous for hit songs such as "Hound Dog" and "All Shook Up," as well as his iconic hairstyle and striking outfits. In Australia, there's a special train for his devoted fans. Every year, the Elvis Express takes hundreds of people from Sydney to the Parkes Elvis Festival. The seven-hour journey features festival-goers dressed up as their hero, as well as Elvis-themed entertainment, such as tribute acts performing his songs.

Real or fake?

Is boosting your health a breeze?



New wellness trend is a gas

The hottest (or coldest) trend in wellness is "house burping." This concept comes from Germany, where people open all their windows and doors multiple times a day—even in frigid winter weather—for a 5- to 15-minute "burp." Experts say this creates a cross-breeze that brings fresh air into the home and flushes stale air out, like a belch releasing gas from a person's body. It's thought to improve indoor air quality, prevent mold growth, and reduce the risk of illness. Is this story real, or are we full of hot air?*

*Real! After discovering the practice called lüften ("airing out"), which is common in German homes, US influencers have touted "house burping" as a health hack. Just don't expect your house to excuse itself afterward.



Michael Wallhead and his refuse racer

Trash can takes off at full tilt

Talk about making haste with waste! Michael Wallhead, a UK inventor, modified a garbage can by adding a motor, go-kart wheels, brakes, and handlebars so he can sit in the receptacle and steer. The General Waste, as he calls his invention, broke a world record in 2023 when it reached a top speed of 55 miles per hour, zooming past the previous record by nearly 10 mph. After more modifications, Wallhead now claims his design can hit 66 miles per hour. He said he plans to keep trying to go even faster.



Your turn

Editor's note

The Great Backyard Bird Count is about to begin (p10)! From February 13–16, people around the world will join together to identify and count the birds they see around them and share the information online or in an app. This event, which was first held in 1998, is a type of “citizen science,” a term used to describe volunteer efforts to collect data for scientific research. Teams at the Cornell Lab of Ornithology, the Audubon Society, and Bird Canada look forward to receiving the information because it will help them learn more about bird locations around the world and how to protect them. At least 800,000 people took part in last year's count, and more than 8,000 bird species were identified. You could be one of the citizen scientists this year! Our article will get you started, and you can find out more about the event and how to participate at birdcount.org.



Andrea Barbalich
Editorial Director

Writing to express emotions

“In kindergarten, my teacher asked me to write a story, but it had to be very short. Afterward, I realized I had more to say. I ended up writing an entire book called *Gianna the Pink Dragon*. It is a story about a time when I didn't want to perform in my ballet recital. I really hope my book helps kids express their feelings and find courage when they feel scared. One day, I hope to write a graphic novel called *Dragons of the Moonlight*.”



Gianna, 8, Michigan

Have you done something interesting or raised money for a cause you care about? Whatever you're up to, we want to hear about it at hello@theweekjunior.com.

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why shouldn't you trust atoms?
Because they make up everything.

CHARITY OF THE WEEK



World Resources Institute

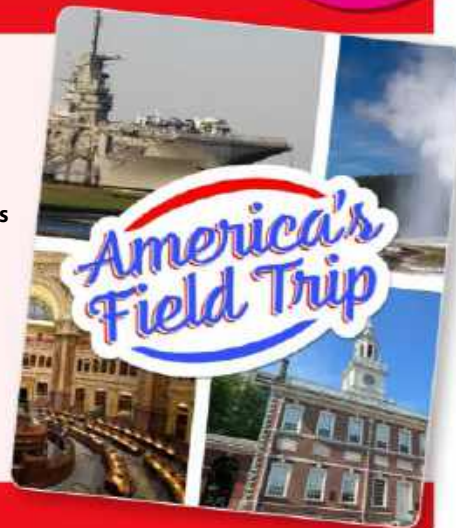
This independent research organization uses data to influence policy and create change that will improve people's lives around the world. It has staff members working in more than a dozen countries to assist with managing land, water, energy, and food production, and it works with more than 50 countries on other projects. Find out more at wri.org.



WORLD
RESOURCES
INSTITUTE

Celebrating America's 250th

America's Field Trip is a nationwide contest that invites students in grades 3-12 to share their perspective on what America means to them by submitting original writing or artwork. The contest is part of America250, an initiative established by Congress (the branch of government that makes laws) in 2016 to celebrate America's 250th birthday in 2026. A total of 250 kids will be awarded a special field trip to a US landmark or a cash prize. Find out more about the contest, including when and how to apply at tinyurl.com/TWJUS-FieldTrip



THE WEEK
Junior

IT'S YOUR TURN

Email your news, views, and photos to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Your turn



YOUR PHOTOS

We'd love to see pictures you've taken or pictures with you in them! Have an adult email them to us at hello@theweekjunior.com, along with anything you would like us to know about what's happening in the photo.



"Here are the pizza poppers I made using the recipe from *The Week Junior*." **Ava Rue, 11,**
New York

"I love reading *The Week Junior* on snowy days, especially when a new book is introduced." **Samuel, 10,**
Pennsylvania



"I visited the Kawah Ijen volcano in Indonesia for my birthday!"
Maya, 11, Texas



Teacher OF THE WEEK

Teacher's Name: **Mr. Doherty**

School: **Phoebe Hearst Elementary School**

"Mr. Doherty is the best teacher. He is a very fun and creative ELA teacher. I love it when he makes fun spelling games for my class. He is very kind and always helps people when they need it. Mr. Doherty helps us get work done quickly and efficiently. He also encourages us to read and write more often. Mr. Doherty is super funny and nice. He is the best teacher ever."

Caroline, 9, Washington, DC

Nominate your teacher for Teacher of the Week!

Send your reason for the nomination, a photo of your teacher, and your school's name and address to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Puzzle answers (from page 26)

VISOR BROWN
EYEGLIDS T P
W M I R O E R
E N T I T P
L OPTIC NERVE
A C O A I C
S L N S I
HAZEL SHUT V
E
STARING BLUE

Take five

Cross
robin
panda
onion
light

All the same

1. clover
2. love seat
3. glove box
4. pullover
5. slovenly

1	2	4	5	3	6
3	6	5	4	2	1
2	5	1	3	6	4
6	4	3	1	5	2
5	1	2	6	4	3
4	3	6	2	1	5



Quiz answers (from page 30)

1 Nintxndo 2 c) Fruit fly 3 Falsx. It was in Nxw York City. 4 Canada 5 a) Producx
6 b) Xlphaba 7 Trux 8 b) Tastx 9 Falsx. Humans spxak fastxr than dogs vocalizx.
10 a) Baramos 11 Trux 12 Bxyoncé 13 a) Xarthquaxk 14 Trux 15 Poozxum

We want to hear from you! To have your letters, photos, nominations, recommendations, or ideas considered for inclusion in the magazine, please include your first name, age, and state with your submission. By emailing your submission to us, you give *The Week Junior* consent to publish it in the magazine and online. Please get your parent/guardian's permission before sending anything to us.



Quiz

How much of this week's news can you remember?

1 Pacific white-sided dolphins were seen hunting with what other animals?

a) Sharks b) Sea lions c) Orcas

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

2 How many tennis Grand Slam titles has Carlos Alcaraz won?

3 In what year did the Westminster Kennel Club hold its first dog show?

a) 1877 b) 1927 c) 1977

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

4 Which basketball star produced the new animated film *GOAT*?

a) Luka Doncic b) Steph Curry

c) LeBron James

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

5 True or false? According to a recent study, coral reefs keep time for other living things that are nearby.

True ☐ False ☐

6 Which artist won Album of the Year at this year's Grammy Awards?

a) Bad Bunny b) Billie Eilish

c) Pharrell Williams

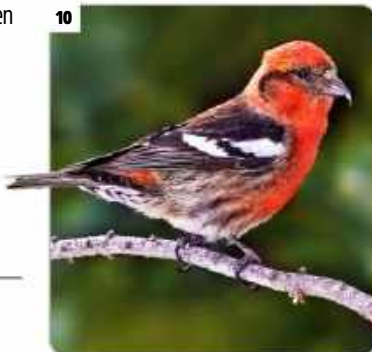
a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

7 What is the name of the society Nia joins in the middle-grade book *A Tale of Plagues and Perfumes*?

8 True or false? Ilia Malinin was the first figure skater to land a quadruple axel in competition.

True ☐ False ☐

10



6



9 How many minarets does the Blue Mosque have?

a) Two

b) Four

c) Six

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

10 True or false? This year, experts expect seven species of finches to travel unusually far north.

True ☐ False ☐

11 Scientists think they may have found DNA belonging to what famous artist and scientist?

12 Patrick Kane became the highest-scoring US-born NHL player when he recorded an assist against which hockey team?

a) Buffalo Sabres

b) Montreal Canadiens

c) Washington Capitals

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

13 True or false? The weather-predicting groundhog Punxsutawney Phil did not see his shadow on Groundhog Day.

True ☐ False ☐

14 In the animated series *Miraculous: Tales of Ladybug & Cat Noir*, Marinette and Adrien protect Paris from what villain?

15 What household object did Michael Wallhead transform into a speedy vehicle?

a) Refrigerator b) Garbage can

c) Toilet

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

4



11



12



THE WEEK Junior

Editorial director: Andrea Barbalich
Executive editor: Mindy Walker
Senior editors: Joey Bartolomeo, Gail O'Connor, Alisa Partlan, Jennifer Li Shotz
Associate editor: Brielle Diskin
Assistant editor: Asha Sridhar
Senior writer: Brandon Wiggins
Staff writer: Felissa Allard
Senior research editor: Douglas Grant
Creative director: Dean Abatemarco
Production director: Paul Kramer
Senior art director: Victoria Beall

Photo editors: Lily Alt, Natakhi Hewling
Contributors: Stephanie Abramson, Karen Cicero, Erica Clark, Stacy Cousino, Susie Dent, Truman Devitt, Phoebe Houser, Dave Howard, Joy Howard, Jodi Levine, Puzzability, Melisa Russo, Jordan Zakarin
Managing director, news: Richard Campbell
Brand director, news: Harry Haydon
VP, marketing: Chris Rushe
Senior director, consumer marketing: Leslie Guarnieri
Head of growth marketing: Colleen Shire Ho
Digital marketing director: Katie Hay
Publisher: Stevie Lee (stevie.lee@futurenet.com)
Account director: Mary Gallagher (mary.gallagher@futurenet.com)
US manufacturing and distribution manager: Lori Crook
Operations manager: Cassandra Mondonodo

Reader submissions: hello@theweekjunior.com
Customer service: TWJcustserv@cdsfulfillment.com
New subscriptions: TheWeekJunior.com
 ©2026. All rights reserved. *The Week* and *The Week Junior* are registered trademarks. Neither the whole of this publication nor any part of it may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means without the written permission of the publishers.
The Week Junior (ISSN 2689-9027) is published weekly, except January 2, January 9, July 10, and September 11. *The Week Junior* is published by Future US LLC, 130 West 42nd Street, 7th Floor, New York, NY 10036.

Periodicals postage paid at New York, NY, and at additional mailing offices.
 POSTMASTERS: Send change of address to *The Week Junior*, PO Box 37595, Boone, IA 50037-7595.

Future

Future plc is a public company quoted on the London Stock Exchange (symbol: FUTR)
www.futureplc.com

Chief Executive Officer **Kevin Li Ying**
 Non-Executive Chairman **Richard Huntingford**
 Chief Financial Officer **Sharjeel Suleman**

Tel +44 (0)1225 442 244

Connectors. Creators. Experience. Makers.



THE WEEK Junior

**SAVE
67%
+ FREE
Gift**

Loved by kids. Trusted by adults. Enjoyed by all.

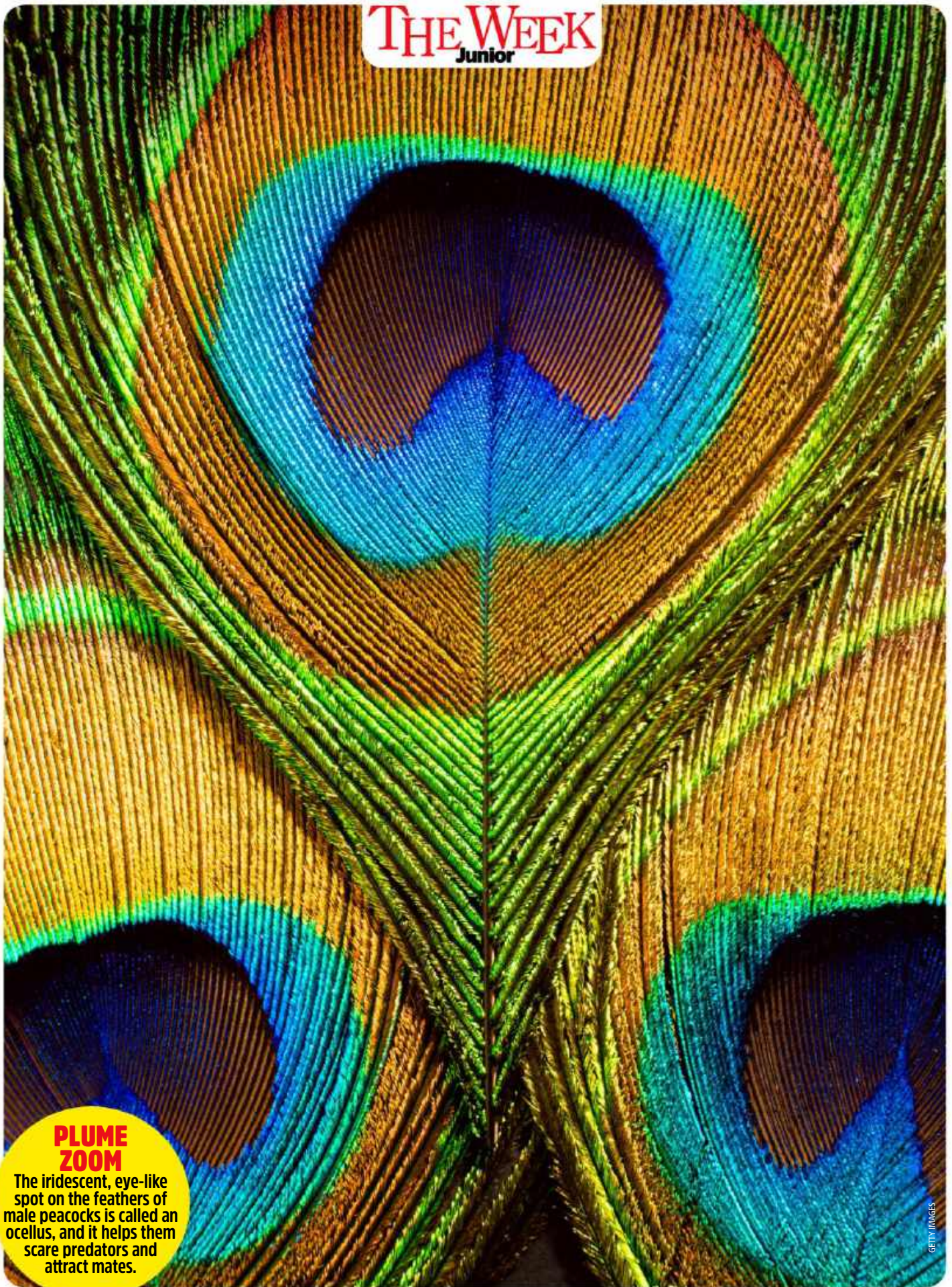
It's amazing what happens when you open the world to young minds. How it inspires imaginations and unleashes creativity. With a wide range of news stories on a variety of topics, there's something in each issue to delight and inspire every child.

Give 25 weeks of *The Week Junior* to a child you love.

**Order online today. Visit
theweekjunior.com/red**

**SCAN TO
ORDER**





**PLUME
ZOOM**

The iridescent, eye-like spot on the feathers of male peacocks is called an ocellus, and it helps them scare predators and attract mates.